PYTHON FOR DATA SCIENCE · LESSON 16 OF 31

pandas I: Series, DataFrames, Reading Data, Selecting and Filtering

Meet the most-used data library. Create Series and DataFrames, read CSV and Excel files, inspect data with head, info and describe, select columns and rows with loc and iloc, filter with conditions and query, sort, add columns and save results, using the Superstore sales data.

Python class 12 | pandas 2.3 / 3.0 | Intermediate | 120 min

By the end of this lesson you can

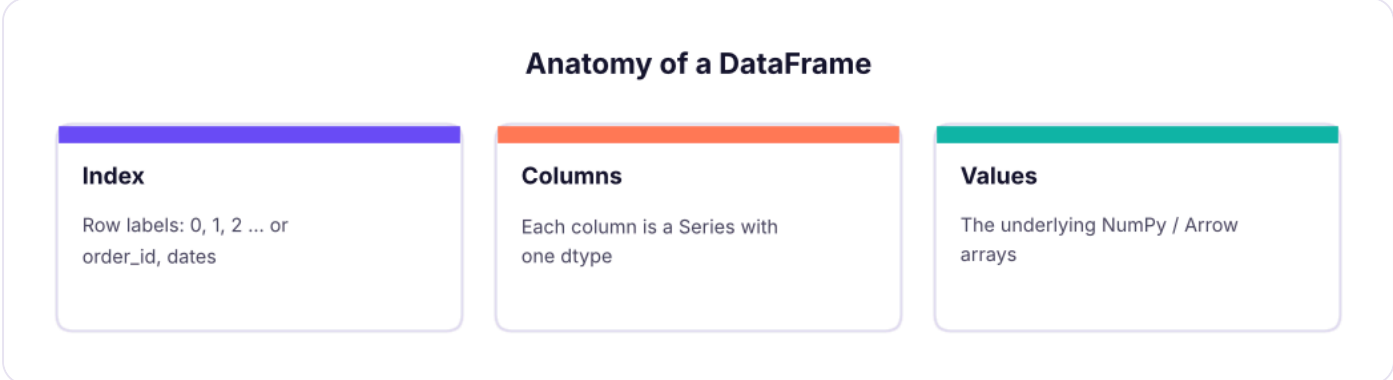
- Create Series and DataFrames and explain the index
- Read CSV and Excel files with the right options and write results back out
- Inspect a dataset with shape, dtypes, head, info, describe and value_counts
- Select with [], loc and iloc and filter rows with boolean conditions, isin, between and query
- Sort, rank, add and rename columns, and avoid the SettingWithCopy pitfall

Datasets used

`superstore_sales.csv` `employees_small.csv`

Series and DataFrame

pandas gives Python spreadsheet-like tables. A **Series** is one labelled column; a **DataFrame** is a table of Series sharing one **index** (row labels).



A DataFrame is a set of Series (columns) that share an index (row labels).

Python

```
import pandas as pd, numpy as np
pd.set_option("display.max_columns", 20); pd.set_option("display.width", 160)   # show wide tables in full
s = pd.Series([120, 95, 140], index=["North", "South", "East"], name="sales")
print(s, s["South"], s.max(), s.idxmax(), sep="\n")
df = pd.DataFrame({"city": ["Pune", "Delhi", "Kochi"], "sales": [120, 95, 140], "target": [100, 110, 130]})
df["hit"] = df["sales"] ⩾ df["target"]
print(df)
print(df.shape, list(df.columns), df.index, df.dtypes.to_dict(), pd.__version__)
```

OUTPUT

```
North    120
South     95
East     140
Name: sales, dtype: int64
95
140
East
    city  sales  target    hit
0   Pune    120     100   True
1  Delhi     95     110  False
2  Kochi    140     130   True
(3, 4) ['city', 'sales', 'target', 'hit'] RangeIndex(start=0, stop=3, step=1)
{'city': dtype('O'), 'sales': dtype('int64'), 'target': dtype('int64'), 'hit': dtype('bool')} 2.3.3
```

Reading data

Python

```
s = pd.read_csv("superstore_sales.csv", parse_dates=["order_date", "ship_date"])
print(s.shape)
print(s.head(3).T)
```

OUTPUT

```
(6323, 19)
                              0                    1                    2
row_id                        1                    2                    3
order_id             IN-2023-00001        IN-2023-00001        IN-2023-00001
order_date     2023-01-01 00:00:00  2023-01-01 00:00:00  2023-01-01 00:00:00
ship_date      2023-01-05 00:00:00  2023-01-05 00:00:00  2023-01-05 00:00:00
ship_mode              Second Class         Second Class         Second Class
```

customer_id	C0765	C0765	C0765
customer_name	Ishaan Gupta	Ishaan Gupta	Ishaan Gupta
segment	Consumer	Consumer	Consumer
city	Bengaluru	Bengaluru	Bengaluru
state	Karnataka	Karnataka	Karnataka
region	South	South	South
product_id	P0059	P0050	P0011
category	Technology	Office Supplies	Furniture
sub_category	Phones	Appliances	Tables
product_name	Nova Phone 223	Orbit Appliance 798	Orbit Table 248
sales	36000.0	3850.0	62080.0
quantity	2	1	4
discount	0.0	0.0	0.0
profit	3472.55	1169.54	6044.47

Option	Use
`sep=";"`	Other delimiters (`"\t"` for TSV)
`usecols=[...]`	Read only some columns (faster, less memory)
`dtype={"pin": str}`	Keep leading zeros and IDs as text
`parse_dates=[...]`	Convert date columns
`na_values=["NA", "-"]`	Extra markers for missing
`nrows=1000` , `chunksize=100_000`	Sample or stream big files
`encoding="latin-1"`	Fix decode errors in older files

Other readers: `pd.read_excel("file.xlsx", sheet_name="Sales")` (needs `openpyxl`), `pd.read_json` , `pd.read_parquet` , `pd.read_sql` (Lesson 23), `pd.read_html` , `pd.read_clipboard` .

Inspecting data

Run these five on every new dataset:

Python

```
print(s.info(memory_usage="deep"))
```

OUTPUT

```
<class 'pandas.core.frame.DataFrame'>
RangeIndex: 6323 entries, 0 to 6322
```

```
Data columns (total 19 columns):
 #   Column         Non-Null Count  Dtype
---  ------         --------------  -----
 0   row_id         6323 non-null   int64
 1   order_id       6323 non-null   object
 2   order_date     6323 non-null   datetime64[ns]
 3   ship_date      6323 non-null   datetime64[ns]
 4   ship_mode      6323 non-null   object
 5   customer_id    6323 non-null   object
 6   customer_name  6323 non-null   object
 7   segment        6323 non-null   object
 8   city           6323 non-null   object
 9   state          6323 non-null   object
 10  region         6323 non-null   object
 11  product_id     6323 non-null   object
 12  category       6323 non-null   object
 13  sub_category   6323 non-null   object
 14  product_name   6323 non-null   object
 15  sales          6323 non-null   float64
 16  quantity       6323 non-null   int64
 17  discount       6323 non-null   float64
 18  profit         6323 non-null   float64
dtypes: datetime64[ns](2), float64(3), int64(2), object(12)
memory usage: 4.6 MB
None
```

Python

```python
print(s.describe(include="number").round(1).T)
print(s["region"].value_counts(), s["category"].value_counts(normalize=True).round(3),
sep="\n")
print(s["customer_id"].nunique(), "customers |", s["order_date"].min().date(), "to",
s["order_date"].max().date())
print(s.isna().sum().sum(), "missing cells |", s.duplicated().sum(), "duplicate rows")
```

OUTPUT

```
             count     mean      std      min     25%     50%      75%       max
row_id      6323.0   3162.0   1825.4      1.0  1581.5  3162.0   4742.5    6323.0
sales       6323.0  31854.1  60414.2     42.0  1564.0  8430.0  32592.0  619290.0
quantity    6323.0      2.6      1.6      1.0     1.0     2.0      3.0       7.0
discount    6323.0      0.1      0.1      0.0     0.0     0.0      0.2       0.4
profit      6323.0   2902.4  11002.0 -75873.8   -17.9   266.3   2270.1  149424.9
region
South     1656
West      1614
North     1530
```

```
East     1523
Name: count, dtype: int64
category
Office Supplies    0.398
Furniture          0.303
Technology         0.299
Name: proportion, dtype: float64
785 customers | 2023-01-01 to 2025-12-31
0 missing cells | 0 duplicate rows
```

Selecting columns and rows

Python

```python
print(s["sales"].head(3).tolist())                    # one column → Series
print(s[["order_id", "region", "sales"]].head(3))     # list of columns → DataFrame
print(s.loc[0, "customer_name"], s.iloc[0, 6])        # loc = labels, iloc = positions
print(s.loc[0:2, "region":"product_id"])               # loc slices INCLUDE the end label
print(s.iloc[0:2, 10:12])                              # iloc slices EXCLUDE the end, like
Python
```

OUTPUT

```
[36000.0, 3850.0, 62080.0]
        order_id region    sales
0  IN-2023-00001  South  36000.0
1  IN-2023-00001  South   3850.0
2  IN-2023-00001  South  62080.0
Ishaan Gupta Ishaan Gupta
  region product_id
0  South      P0059
1  South      P0050
2  South      P0011
  region product_id
0  South      P0059
1  South      P0050
```

Tool	Selects by	Example
`df["col"]` / `df[["a","b"]]`	Column names	`s["sales"]`
`df.loc[rows, cols]`	**Labels** and boolean masks	`s.loc[s.profit < 0, ["order_id", "profit"]]`
`df.iloc[rows, cols]`	**Integer positions**	`s.iloc[:5, :3]`
`df.at[r, c]` / `df.iat[i, j]`	One value, fast	`s.at[0, "sales"]`

Filtering rows

Python

```
loss = s[s["profit"] < 0]
print(len(loss), "loss-making lines")
tech_south = s[(s["category"] == "Technology") & (s["region"] == "South")]           # & |
~ need brackets
print(len(tech_south), round(tech_south["sales"].sum() / 1e6, 2), "M")
print(s[s["city"].isin(["Pune", "Kochi"])]["city"].value_counts().to_dict())
print(len(s[s["discount"].between(0.1, 0.2)]),
len(s[s["product_name"].str.contains("Chair")]))
print(s.query("region == 'West' and sales > 50000 and discount == 0")[["order_id",
"sales"]].head(3))
big = 50000
print(len(s.query("sales > @big")))                    # @ refers to a Python variable
```

OUTPUT

```
1682 loss-making lines
495 41.89 M
{'Pune': 529, 'Kochi': 417}
1943 493
         order_id    sales
7   IN-2023-00003  69280.0
22  IN-2023-00013  72000.0
98  IN-2023-00051  64450.0
1126
```

Sorting and ranking

Python

```
top = s.sort_values("sales", ascending=False)[["order_id", "product_name",
"sales"]].head(5)
print(top)
print(s.sort_values(["region", "profit"], ascending=[True,
False]).groupby("region").head(1)[["region", "product_name", "profit"]])
print(s.nlargest(3, "profit")[["product_name", "profit"]], s.nsmallest(2, "profit")
[["product_name", "profit"]], sep="\n")
```

OUTPUT

```
          order_id       product_name     sales
3669  IN-2024-01857   Orbit Copier 746  619290.0
2087  IN-2024-01040  Vertex Copier 262  551530.0
1142  IN-2023-00564  Vertex Copier 262  551530.0
5696  IN-2025-02880   Orbit Copier 746  530820.0
1653  IN-2023-00809   Orbit Copier 746  526396.5
     region       product_name     profit
4219   East   Orbit Copier 746  135564.21
3669  North   Orbit Copier 746  149424.89
3893  South    Apex Copier 347  107757.96
481    West  Zenith Copier 719   95485.58
         product_name     profit
3669  Orbit Copier 746  149424.89
4219  Orbit Copier 746  135564.21
3893   Apex Copier 347  107757.96
            product_name    profit
5979    Orbit Copier 746 -75873.84
639   Pioneer Copier 366 -67392.75
```

Adding, changing and removing columns

Python

```
e = pd.read_csv("employees_small.csv", parse_dates=["join_date"])
e["bonus"] = e["salary"] * 0.1                                    # vectorised
arithmetic
e["band"] = np.where(e["salary"] ⩾ 100000, "Senior", "Standard")      # IF
e["grade"] = pd.cut(e["salary"], bins=[0, 70000, 100000, np.inf], labels=["C", "B", "A"])
# bins
e["tenure_yrs"] = ((pd.Timestamp("2025-10-27") - e["join_date"]).dt.days / 365.25).round(1)
e = e.assign(name_upper=e["name"].str.upper()).rename(columns={"rating":
"perf"}).drop(columns=["name_upper"])
e["salary_rank"] = e["salary"].rank(ascending=False, method="dense").astype(int)
print(e.head(6))
```

OUTPUT

```
  emp_id              name department       city  join_date  salary  perf    bonus
band grade  tenure_yrs  salary_rank
0   E101         Kavya Iyer         HR     Mumbai 2016-02-28   97000     4   9700.0
Standard     B         9.7            8
1   E102        Imran Reddy    Finance      Delhi 2019-12-14  157000     3  15700.0
Senior     A         5.9            1
2   E103  Harpreet Kulkarni    Finance     Mumbai 2024-10-05  131000     4  13100.0
Senior     A         1.1            4
3   E104          Diya Iyer         HR  Bengaluru 2024-01-02   90000     4   9000.0
Standard     B         1.8            9
4   E105        Simran Iyer         HR  Bengaluru 2017-08-03  139000     4  13900.0
Senior     A         8.2            3
5   E106         Saanvi Rao         HR      Delhi 2025-02-18   83000     4   8300.0
Standard     B         0.7           10
```

WATCH OUT **SettingWithCopyWarning**

`sub = df[df.x > 0]; sub["y"] = 1` may warn because `sub` might be a view. Use `df.loc[df.x > 0, "y"] = 1` to change the original, or `sub = df[df.x > 0].copy()` for an independent table. pandas 3 makes copy-on-write the default, which removes the ambiguity.

Saving results

Python

```
out = s.groupby("region", as_index=False)["sales"].sum()
out.to_csv("region_sales.csv", index=False)
print(open("region_sales.csv").read())
import os; os.remove("region_sales.csv")
```

OUTPUT

```
region,sales
East,46484119.0
North,49018161.0
South,53952768.5
West,51958520.5
```

Also: `to_excel("out.xlsx", sheet_name="Summary", index=False)`, `to_parquet` (fast, typed, compressed), `to_json(orient="records")`, `to_sql`.

pandas vs Excel vs SQL

Task	Excel	SQL	pandas
Filter	AutoFilter	`WHERE`	`df[df.x > 5]` / `query`
New column	Formula	`SELECT a*b AS c`	`df["c"] = df.a * df.b`
Sort	Sort	`ORDER BY`	`sort_values`
Lookup	XLOOKUP	`JOIN`	`merge` (Lesson 18)
Pivot	PivotTable	`GROUP BY`	`groupby`, `pivot_table` (Lesson 18)

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- A DataFrame is a table of Series sharing an index; read files with `read_csv` / `read_excel` and the right options.
- Inspect first: `shape`, `info()`, `describe()`, `value_counts()`, `isna().sum()`, `duplicated().sum()`.
- Select with `[]` (columns), `loc` (labels, end-inclusive) and `iloc` (positions, end-exclusive).
- Filter with boolean masks using `&`, `|`, `~` and brackets, plus `isin`, `between`, `str.contains`, `query`.
- Add columns with vectorised maths, `np.where`, `pd.cut`; use `.loc` or `.copy()` to avoid SettingWithCopy issues.

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What does `s[["region", "sales"]]` return?

A A Series

B A DataFrame with two columns

C A list

D An error

Answer: B. Double brackets pass a list of columns.

2. Which is end-inclusive?

A `df.loc[0:2]`

B `df.iloc[0:2]`

C Both

D Neither

Answer: A. `loc` uses labels and includes the end label.

3. Which filter is correct?

A `df[df.a > 1 and df.b < 5]`

B `df[(df.a > 1) & (df.b < 5)]`

C `df[df.a > 1 & df.b < 5]`

D `df.where(a > 1, b < 5)`

Answer: B. Use `&` with brackets around each condition.

4. How do you keep leading zeros in a PIN or ID column when reading?

A `parse_dates`

B `dtype={"pin": str}`

C `usecols`

D `index_col`

Answer: B. Otherwise pandas reads it as a number.

5. Which command shows column types and non-null counts?

A `describe()`

B `info()`

C `head()`

D `shape`

Answer: B. `describe()` gives statistics.

6. How do you reference a Python variable inside `query`?

A `{var}`

B `@var`

C `$var`

D `var()`

Answer: B. `df.query("sales > @big")`.

EXERCISE

pandas practice (Superstore)

(1) How many orders (unique `order_id`) are there? (2) Show the 5 most profitable sub-categories by total profit. (3) Filter Consumer-segment orders in 2025 with discount above 20%. (4) Add `margin_pct` and list the 3 lowest-margin product names among lines with sales above 20,000. (5) Save the Technology rows to `tech.csv`.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
print(s["order_id"].nunique())
print(s.groupby("sub_category")["profit"].sum().nlargest(5))
f = s[(s.segment == "Consumer") & (s.order_date.dt.year == 2025) & (s.discount >
0.2)]; print(len(f))
s["margin_pct"] = 100 * s.profit / s.sales
print(s[s.sales > 20000].nsmallest(3, "margin_pct")[["product_name", "margin_pct"]])
s[s.category == "Technology"].to_csv("tech.csv", index=False)
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: loc vs iloc? `loc` selects by label (and boolean masks), end-inclusive; `iloc` selects by integer position, end-exclusive.

Q: How do you find and handle duplicates? `df.duplicated(subset=[...]).sum()` to count, `drop_duplicates(subset=..., keep="first")` to remove, after deciding which columns define a duplicate.

Q: How do you read a file that does not fit in memory? `usecols` and `dtype` to shrink it, `chunksize` to stream it, or use DuckDB/Polars/Parquet.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.